An-an Lee

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Missing in the Night

GM-01

The Ghost Master

Missing in the Night

Hallway, Deep in the Night

Treading lightly through the maze of candles and piled paper, the team moves with deliberate caution, their steps barely making a sound.

Foundation Staff Member I: There's something off about this wind. It sounds creepy, like someone's heaving a sigh. Don't you think, Joshua? Aren't you scared?

Foundation Staff Member II: You're joking, right? Joshua's one of the St. Pavlov Foundation's top investigators, William. I mean, after what happened at Green Lake, I thought everyone knew about him.

Horropedia: Uhh. Let's try not to pigeonhole people, Millie. And why don't we keep that bit of info under our hats, eh?

Horropedia: Once this investigation's wrapped up, that'll be the time for the lead to exit stage left.

He squats before the iron door and runs two fingers along the floor.

Horropedia: This dust is pretty built up. I'd say the disappearance happened much earlier than we originally thought.

Horropedia: And look at all these bills and advertising flyers.

thwack

Horropedia: Hey! Jeez, that hurt! Who smacked my head?!

The landlady, her hair a mass of curlers and a toothpick wedged between her teeth, is looming behind him with a rolled-up newspaper clutched in her hand.

Landlady: What do you think you're doing sneaking around my property? And you—yeah, you with the glasses! What's up with you, huh?

Landlady: Creeping around with those shifty little eyes ... Just you wait. I'll have the cops here before you can say "unlawful entry"!

Foundation Staff Member II: Ma'am, we've already informed the local police. We've got official permission to investigate this building.

Landlady: Investigate what?! There's nothing wrong with my building! And don't you even think about messing with my tenants, unless you're looking to get reported!

Millie flashes the St. Pavlov Foundation's investigation permit.

Landlady: "St. Pavlova Foundation"? What're you, some kind of Australian dessert police?

Foundation Staff Member II: We're currently looking into the disappearance of two members of the Paranormal Affairs Bureau.

Foundation Staff Member II: Your tenant, Ms. An-an Lee, is one of our freelancers, though it's been a while since we last heard from her.

The landlady walks between them, doubt still coloring her face.

Landlady: This door's been broken for ages. You'll never get it open.

Landlady: But hey, she still hasn't paid the rent, so why should I bother getting someone in to fix it?

Despite her warning, the door creaks open after a gentle touch.

Foundation Staff Member II: ...!

The gum that was holding open the door lock drops to the floor.

The landlady spits out her toothpick and struts smugly into the newly opened office.

Landlady: Hah, nice try. You wanna play, little girl? Let's play!

The others go inside, but Horropedia remains by the doorway. He crouches down to take in the disarray around the entrance.

Foundation Staff Member II: Joshua?

She follows his gaze until her eyes land on the floor. Among the crumpled newspapers and scattered flyers, a single piece of white paper catches her eye.

Horropedia: What time is it now?

Millie shrugs and glances at her watch.

Foundation Staff Member II: Almost midnight. Any new orders from the Foundation?

Horropedia: No. We need to go. We need to go now! We're running out of time!

Finally, the significance of that white sheet of paper dawns on the two Foundation members.

Foundation Staff Members: ...?!

Landlady: Well? What are you all standing there for? Come in already! I didn't go through all this trouble for nothing!

Landlady: Hold on a second. You're not leaving just like that! If she's on your payroll, you need to pay me her rent!

As they hurry off, a gust of wind suddenly slams the door shut.

Landlady: About that rent ...

Landlady: Hey! Hey, wait up! I'm not done yet! And this door's still messed up!

She bangs on the metal door like a deranged housecat.

Landlady: Hey, come back here! I'm locked in! Four-eyes! Come back, you ungrateful jerks!

But their footsteps continue to grow more distant.

Foundation Staff Member II: Sorry, ma'am! Things aren't looking so good right now. We don't have time to break you out!

Horropedia: We'll be back before you can say, "Get me out of here!"

The landlady clenches her two great fists.

Landlady: Get me out of here!! Agh, bunch of good-for-nothings! Next time I see you, I'm reporting you to your boss—no, scratch that—I'm gonna sue you for ten times the rent in emotional damages!

As her eyes adjust to the darkness, she finally notices the stark piece of white paper on the ground.

She picks it up and squints as she reads each word in a slow and measured tone.

Landlady: "Lighthouse, midnight, get there before two heads roll."

...

Her head throbs. It feels as though it could split open at any moment as her surroundings twist and blur.

A stream of blood runs down her forehead and splatters onto the floor.

???: We meet again, kiddo.

An-an Lee: Uh ...

Lighthouse

An-an Lee: Who ...

She lifts her chin, finding a stubbled face and a pair of weary, sunken eyes before her.

The man's collar is stained yellow with neck grease. As he crouches, his grimy underwear peeks out from his slouchy pants.

One hand scratches an ankle to a foot jammed in a loose and tattered flip-flop.

An-an Lee: Sifu?!

The Young Exorcist

GM-02

The Young Exorcist

Walled City

In this dilapidated Walled City, newspapers once laid on the ground by the homeless now flutter and drift through the air.

Wisps of incense smoke spiral upward, shrouding the darkness in a haze of gray.

A forgotten corner of the city—a sunken area referred to by the elders as a forbidden zone. To enter it is to invite every vice in the world into your heart and condemn yourself to a wretched purgatory of your own creation.

At least that's what the elders and the TV say.

Kong: Alright, get her bag first, and let's see what's inside. Take the cash and her pens and books and stuff.

An-an Lee: ...

Kong: Let go, you little punk!

The boy kicks her hard, sending her crashing to the floor.

Her backpack is ripped from her grasp and thrown to the ground.

Kong: Yo, Chunk, hold her by the shoulders, real tight like. This city girl's guarding her bag like it's made of gold or something.

Chunk: If there's food in there, I got dibs on half of it.

Chunk leans forward and clamps her wrists.

Kong picks up the backpack and tips out its contents onto the ground.

He flings the empty backpack into the bushes.

Kong: Heh, what do we have here? Cling film, cleaning stuff, some talisman paper, a wooden sword, and a lousy book.

Kong: Tch, what a load of worthless crap.

He gives her possessions a few uninterested glances before finally dropping them to the ground.

Kong: Gah, not even a single penny.

Chunk: Tch, I thought she'd have something, easy. Guess she's just playing dress-up, huh?

The grip on An-an's wrists loosens.

She holds her head high, unfazed by the threat looming over her.

An-an Lee: Hey, big guy. This ghost you said you'd take me to see, it's somewhere around here, right?

Kong: Huh? The hell she talking about?! Her brain's gotta be fried.

Chunk: ...

He neither denies nor confirms it.

An-an Lee drops to the ground, narrowing her eyes as she scans the dilapidated buildings around her.

Kong: Hey, what's up with you? You tripping or something?

She turns her attention from the door of the building to the narrow space between the two adjacent skyscrapers.

She takes a step back, then another, until she can see the whole scene clearly.

An-an Lee: This is ...!

She drops to her knees, the dirt pressing into her skin, and frantically opens the book lying on the ground.

She turns page after page.

An-an Lee: "Tian Zhan Sha"?

An-an Lee: No worries, still got time. Let me check.

The sky darkens as a mass of black clouds rushes in, choking the moonlight.

The lights hanging in the hallway begin to flicker.

The eerie contraption flashes with a vivid red warning.

An-an Lee: Hmm, that's not right. The book didn't say it would happen this fast.

An-an Lee: Hey! Dumbasses! Get over to the light, quick! "They" are coming for us!

Chunk: What are you talking ab—

A hand drops onto his shoulder.

???: Wooooo ...

???: I will &*$# ... all of you.

An-an Lee: Run!

She levies a swift and brutal kick to his back.

Kong & Chunk: Ahhhhhhhh!

The youngsters scramble into a corner, desperate for somewhere to hide.

The young, self-taught exorcist crouches down, clutching her peach-wood sword.

An-an Lee: *panting*

???: Haha. Hmm? Been out of the game too long, huh? This little one's got some moves. I didn't know Kowloon had such talent.

He runs a hand through his messy hair and pulls at the yellow collar of his grubby shirt. He oozes the foul scent of booze from the previous night.

???: This is ...

His toes, which are hanging past the edge of his flip-flops, brush against the book lying on the floor.

Strange Man: Tsk, that baldy really just went ahead and sold this thing at some street stall.

Strange Man: The nerve of that guy. Totally shameless. One day he's gonna find himself in more trouble than he can handle, and there'll be no way out of it.

He brushes the dirt off the book and stuffs it into his pocket.

An-an Lee: Hey, old man! What's the big idea, huh? That 13 Holy Exorcism Techniques is mine, you hear me!

Strange Man: ...

He pulls the book from his ragged coat and dangles it by two fingers like bait.

An-an Lee: Hey. Hey! Gimme that back ah!

She leaps up, her hands outstretched, yet the book remains just beyond her grasp.

Strange Man: Your little ghost-hunting game's over, girlie.

rrrrip

He tears the book in two and then into four. White scraps of paper spiral down into the darkness of the lower levels beneath them.

An-an Lee: N-No!

She charges forward without a second thought, only to be firmly restrained.

An-an Lee: What's your deal, huh? Let me go! That book's mine!

Strange Man: What's my deal? That book's filled with a bunch of made-up crap. You'll get yourself into some real trouble if you believe even a word of it! I should know. I'm the one who wrote the damn thing! Almost lost my mind doing it!

An-an Lee: Huh?

Strange Man: *"... In the end, ghosts are just the product of collective imagination and mass hysteria."*

Strange Man: *"They're nothing but a form of energy, shaped by what you imagine them to be, like wind, radiation, or even bad gas, just a kind of energy you can't see."*

Strange Man: *"That's why ghosts in different parts of the world are so distinct."*

Strange Man: Got it?

His words match those in the book exactly.

An-an Lee: What?! No way! You're Demi-Divine Chen, the guy who could see spirits at five and started exorcizing evil at eight?! Didn't all those arcanists say you were pushing up daisies already?

An-an Lee: Hey, your eyes work just fine, don't they?

An-an Lee: Hey, hey, Sifu! Where you running off to?!

Chen quickens his pace, trying to escape before he draws any more attention.

An-an Lee: Hey, Sifu, how about it? You gonna take me on as your apprentice or not?! I've been dreaming of learning from you for ages! I got cash saved up! I can pay tuition!!

As she tugs on his clothing, the man stops.

Strange Man: It's the middle of the night, kiddo. Keep it down. Look, I don't do apprentices, so you should just head home.

Strange Man: Exorcism ain't child's play. You're just a kid. You looking to shorten your lifespan? Ever seen a dead body before? You think it's all just fun and games?

Strange Man: This racket'll kill ya!

The girl cocks her head.

An-an Lee: Eh? Of course, I know all that. I'm not scared! Not one bit! That's exactly why I should be doing this stuff!

A brief flash of surprise flickers in his eyes, but only for a moment.

He wrenches himself free from the small hand clinging to his clothes and slips into a narrow alley.

Strange Man: Go get your head checked at the department of neurology!

An-an Lee: Wait!

"Safety Briefings"

GM-03

"Safety Briefings"

Abandoned Cabin

The floor is strewn with yellowed newspapers. Moths flutter around the lampshade in endless circles.

The nearby wooden ladder creaks, and the doors and windows shudder with the wind.

Despite the fragility of the house, a single door is all it takes to keep her at bay.

She has long since lost count of how long she's been coming here.

An-an Lee: Sifu, I-I'm serious! I want to be your student!

An-an Lee: Ever since I picked up your book at that street market, I've been reading it nonstop!

An old, wonky iron pot filled with leftover vegetables thrown out by stall vendors and unprocessed frozen meat from the butcher's shop is boiling nearby.

The man is sprawled across a pile of papers. He tears a few small strips, crumples them into a ball, and jams them into his ears.

An-an Lee: I'll come tomorrow, and the day after, and the day after that! I'll come find you, no matter when, no matter what!

An-an Lee: I'll become the most badass Tianshi in Kowloon, I swear it!

As the rain falls even harder outside, her voice grows increasingly faint.

He gets up and starts walking.

An-an Lee: Sifu!

Demi-Divine Chen: Rain's too hard out there. Just come in, alright? Can't have you dying on my doorstep, or you'll get me in trouble with the cops.

An-an Lee: Ah ... Ah-choo!

Rolls of toilet paper lay piled on the floor like bandages torn from a mummy.

Demi-Divine Chen: Now listen, I can't take you on as a student, alright? You don't respect fear. You're like a baby—ain't got a clue what a cliff is, so you're happy to walk right up to the edge of it. I ain't gonna be stuck cleaning up the mess when some clueless kid ends up going splat.

Demi-Divine Chen: You need to learn what fear is first. No one can teach you that, especially not me.

An-an Lee: Huh? But Sifu, that's the whole reason why I wanna be your apprentice. I wanna find something that can actually make me feel scared.

An-an Lee: I ... I just wanna know what fear feels like! That's why I'm so into exorcizing.

Her words hang cold in the air.

Demi-Divine Chen: Kiddo, quit trying to make it sound so innocent when you're really just here for kicks.

Demi-Divine Chen: Admit it, you're just another one of those little rich girls sneaking out of your fancy apartment to get a kick out of this place, ain't ya?

Demi-Divine Chen: You wanna "know what fear feels like"? Listen to yourself. What a joke!

An-an Lee: Tch, fine. If you don't wanna teach me, then don't. But don't start acting like those lame teachers who lecture me all the time.

She drops her head as she continues to mutter to herself.

Chen doesn't utter a word. Instead, he just keeps stirring the bubbling food in the pot.

The rain patters outside while the fire hisses and crackles.

An-an Lee, curled up in a corner wrapped in old clothes, drifts into sleep. Before long, her rhythmic snoring fills the room.

Demi-Divine Chen: Yo, kiddo, this ain't some daycare, you know.

He shakes her arm in an attempt to wake her.

Then, he notices a birthmark on it—or, no, a burn.

Demi-Divine Chen: ...!

Demi-Divine Chen: Ain't no way this is just a coincidence. Damn it.

...

...

Police Office

Radio: "... Sources report that the fire on Xing Street has left four dead and three critically injured. Authorities have apprehended the suspects, and the survivors are currently under police protection."

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: Turn that off. Don't wake the girl.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: If it weren't for her special eyes, this arcane case would've been dead in the water, and we'd be back on patrol duty.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer II: But we can't just keep the kid here like this. Doesn't she have any other family besides her parents? Are we gonna have to send her into foster care?

He glances at the girl on the couch. She's lying still with her back to them.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: She has a distant aunt. Says she's on her way.

Unseen by the officers, her eyes remain open, blank, and glued to the wall.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: This kid's something else. Stared right at her parents' burned corpses and didn't even flinch—not even a tear.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: Word is, when the officer showed up, there were dozens of ghosts closing in on her. But she was just huddled completely still with those burns on her hands. Wasn't trying to get away or anything.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: She didn't come in for a statement until we'd cleared her parents' bodies.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: The bodies were alright, but man, the way her eyes are always just ... staring like that. I dunno, it creeps me out. I swear I haven't seen her blink.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer II: Yeah. Doesn't cry, doesn't laugh, just has that blank, dead expression on her face. She doesn't act like a kid at all.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: They say that only the "possessed" don't get scared like that.

The officer adopts a deliberate, grim frown.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: Maybe this kid isn't even human anymore.

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer II: ...?!

Division of Arcane Affairs Officer I: Hahaha, you should see the look on your face! Relax. I'm just messing with you.

Sunlight creeps in through a crack in the door.

Chen holds her arm, inspecting it from all sides, as though it's some sort of specimen.

An-an Lee: You done yet, Sifu? My arm's getting stiff.

Demi-Divine Chen: You said this scar was from the big fire on Xing Street a year ago, right?

He lowers her arm, but his eyes repeatedly flick back to it, as if needing further confirmation.

Demi-Divine Chen: Does that mean you're the girl who was on the news? Your parents ...

An-an Lee: Oh, so you know about all that, Sifu? Guess I'm pretty famous, huh? Hah hah.

An-an rubs her arm, her demeanor unexpectedly composed for someone so young.

She makes it seem as though the tragedy was just another everyday occurrence.

Demi-Divine Chen: I never thought Lady Luck would find me this fast.

Demi-Divine Chen: The heavens have smiled upon me! Haha! You don't know how wrong you were, you blind old fool!

An-an Lee: Huh? What are you talking about, Sifu?

He stamps out the fire, a cryptic grin curling at the corners of his mouth.

A mix of relief and intense satisfaction washes over him, like when you tear open a scab to savor the pain.

Demi-Divine Chen: Hahahahaha!

Demi-Divine Chen: You're really dying to be my student, huh? Then, alright, kiddo, let's do this!

He flings the door open in an almost mad frenzy, grabbing the girl's hand as he charges out.

An-an Lee: Whoa, Sifu! Where are we going now?

Demi-Divine Chen: Under the Bridge.

Under the Bridge

Cars rush over the bridge above, their thunderous roars reverberating through the arches and rumbling beneath their feet.

Beneath, a crowd of customers bustles, each of them seeking to know their fortune. One merchant, who was previously on the verge of tears, beams with joy as his fortune is told. Meanwhile, a group of foreign tourists' smiles fade as a palm reader issues them a solemn warning.

Each customer dreams of seeing what lies beyond destiny's veil. Though some spend their last coin here, others strike it rich with destiny's ultimate jackpot.

And that is how this location, known only as "Under the Bridge," has earned its infamous reputation.

Blind Fortune Teller: Here. Crush this talisman into pieces and eat a little three times a day after meals for three days, and all will be well.

Tourist: Thank you, master! You're a lifesaver!

Blind Fortune Teller: Wait!

The blind fortune teller sniffs the air, detecting a familiar odor.

An-an Lee: Whoa, Sifu, I didn't know there was such a big place down here! Could open a new office down here! You don't wanna live here?

Demi-Divine Chen: Hurry it up, kid. Ain't nothing worth seeing here.

He pulls An-an as she tries to take in her surroundings, her head swiveling as she tries to see it from every angle.

A hand grabs his collar.

Blind Fortune Teller: Well, well, heh-heh. If it isn't Demi-Divine Chen! I thought you'd already made it big. What are you still doing walking around Under the Bridge, eh?

An-an Lee: Huh? Aren't you supposed to be blind, mister?

She waves her hand in front of the fortune teller's sunglasses.

Blind Fortune Teller: Even a blind man can light a lamp. Blind eyes don't make for a blind heart, missy. I had already foreseen his return.

Blind Fortune Teller: As for you, little lady.

He snatches An-an's waving hand and grips it tight.

Blind Fortune Teller: Remarkable bones. Heh-heh. What a fine specimen you are. Your destiny is in perfect balance after surviving such a calamity. Certainly not one to be confined by anything.

Blind Fortune Teller: But ... your parents ...

Blind Fortune Teller: *sigh* It's too soon. Far too soon. You shouldn't have brought her here.

Demi-Divine Chen: Hey! Let go, you blind old fool.

Chen's expression turns dark as he drags An-an off.

An-an Lee: Sifu?

He continues to pull her without a word, barging through the crowd.

As they go, An-an's eyes remain fixed on the blind fortune teller under the bridge, as if holding a non-existent gaze.

Blind Fortune Teller: There's no escaping it! Accept your destiny!

A bottomless well yawns before them. Chen stands at the edge and takes a deep breath.

Demi-Divine Chen: Listen up, kiddo. This well, they call it Destiny. It's been here since long before this bridge even existed.

Demi-Divine Chen: If you wanna be an exorcist and study under me, you're gonna have to dive into this well and pull your own calamity hexagram out of the muck at the bottom of it.

Demi-Divine Chen: This is the first karmic trial for any exorcist. Once you pass this test, you'll be worthy of calling yourself an exorcist.

He loosens the dirt around the well's edge and pulls out a rusty copper chain.

Demi-Divine Chen: Otherwise, it ends here. You go your way, I go mine, and you don't come bothering me anymore, you hear?

An-an Lee: For real? Too easy! Let me take a look.

She clutches the rim of the well as she leans over to stare into the abyss below.

The well's walls are thick with complex yellow talismans, as if they've grown from the bottom like ivy.

The deeper it goes, the more tightly packed the talismans become, until not a single ray of light can be seen.

An-an Lee: Tch ...

A cold wind rushes from the bottom of the well, sending a shiver down her spine.

Demi-Divine Chen: Alright, listen up. I'm gonna wrap this chain around you. Then, you get in the bucket, and I'll lower you down to the bottom, nice and slow. Now—

He unfastens the Three-Clarities Bell from his belt and secures it around the girl's waist.

Demi-Divine Chen: Keep this bell on. If you run into any trouble, ring it three times, and I'll pull you up in a flash.

Demi-Divine Chen: Got it? You want out, you ring the bell.

An-an Lee: Got it, Sifu! You know I'm a night owl. Darkness doesn't scare me. I can handle it. I'll pull that calamity hexagram right out. Just don't go back on your word, okay?

She climbs into the bucket, and he slowly lowers her into the well.

At first, she feels like a stone sinking into the ocean, the light still caught in her eyes, but then darkness envelops her, and she is left in complete darkness.

In the blink of an eye ...

The stone hits the bottom.

...

Blind Fortune Teller: She doesn't know, does she? That you've never been to the bottom of that well—never faced your own trial.

Blind Fortune Teller: She doesn't know that you were the one who performed an unlicensed exorcism and burned down those buildings a year ago. Oh yes, heh-heh, I know she's the orphan who made the headlines!

Blind Fortune Teller: The cops might not have pinned it on you, but the karma you've sown ... Hah! You'll reap it in time!

Blind Fortune Teller: And no Tianshi has ever let anyone so young go down the well! Even if she does come back, she'll be in a trance for days. Some of her three souls and seven spirits are bound to be lost forever.

Blind Fortune Teller: You're totally unfit to be an exorcist. You realize that, don't you? You've already hurt so many people, and now you're going to hurt her too?

Demi-Divine Chen: You blind fool, just wait and see.

Demi-Divine Chen: One calamity cancels out another. I brought her here. If she doesn't survive, her calamity will bury mine, and I'll finally have peace.

Demi-Divine Chen: Once she rings the bell, our karmic connection will end, and we'll both be safe. We'll part ways, at peace, and there'll be nothing owed between us.

Blind Fortune Teller: My Sifu up in the heavens, I shouldn't have given you my eyes! It's not too late. There's still time to make this right!

The blind man lunges forward and tries to lift the chain with his bare hands. The tremendous force carving bloody gashes into his palms.

But the chain remains unmoved.

Demi-Divine Chen: It's pointless. This is her trial to bear. No one intervenes unless that bell rings.

Blind Fortune Teller: Heavens, this is terrible! If her trial leads to her end down there, you won't get away with it!

Demi-Divine Chen: It's worth the risk. Who knows? Even a bicycle could turn into a motorcycle.

...

Red Binding Thread

GM-04

Red Binding Thread

You can hear them, can't you?

You're just like me—another poor thing they've cast aside.

Another child left behind and forgotten.

An-an Lee: Huh? Where's that voice coming from? A cop's walkie-talkie, or is it some kind of off-screen narration thing?

Her hand brushes against the well's wall. She feels the damp moss clinging to it.

The well's bottom is inescapable. The stones form a cramped, stifling cage.

An-an Lee: Hold on! The moss ... Is it moving?

As the moss creeps and crawls like a thousand centipedes, the wall fades away.

Now, I can feel you, too.

An-an Lee: ...!

Little Rooney: Okay, big mouth! Think you're so special, with those yin-yang eyes you're always bragging about, huh? Then have fun sleeping in here tonight!

He pats the metal cabinet bound in chains.

Little Rooney: I hear this old classroom gets real lively around midnight. Since you were so happy to mess up our plan and get us in trouble, how about I give you the chance to see a real ghost?

Little Rooney: Yo, pour some of the crow's blood on the cabinet! You're her bestie, aren't ya? Lend a hand, won't ya?

He pulls at the girl's hair, pushing her roughly toward the cabinet.

Zhenmei: I don't want to do this, An-an. I-I'm sorry. *sob*

An-an stares through the gaps in the cabinet.

An-an Lee: Eh? What am I doing here?

An-an Lee: Wait, is this like one of those creepy movies where I have to relive all my fears and sadness, basically all the messed-up stuff that happened to me, all over again?

An-an Lee: Then, I must be the main character! I'm gonna level up and beat the crap out of all those creepy creepsters!

An-an Lee: But hang on. I'm not scared one bit! So, doesn't that mean I won't "level up" at all?!

An-an Lee: This is ...

The Darkness Under the Bed: I've been waiting for you down here for so long. You do remember me, don't you?

The Darkness Under the Bed: Those old dolls you threw down here, hee-hee-hee. Their bodies have really come in handy.

Numerous twisted hands extend from beneath the bed, grabbing and clawing at her ankles.

An-an Lee: ...!

The arms drag her, their sharp nails scraping her legs and drawing blood.

She slips and falls.

An-an Lee: Hahaha, so itchy ah! Stop tickling my feet! Hahahaha! You guys seriously need to work on your technique!

An-an Lee: Hey, you're doing it all wrong! And couldn't you clean your nails first? How's your customer supposed to feel comfortable with them all dirty like that? Let me show you how it's done!

She clutches one of the bloodied hands, folds the fingers, and demonstrates by scraping the knuckles across the sole of her foot.

An-an Lee: Hey, the old massage guy downstairs from my place says ... ah, this is the Yongquan point. With all the time you spend under the bed, it's no wonder you're always getting headaches. So damp and humid down there.

An-an Lee: Now, how about this one?!

Just as her massage course nears its end, a blinding white light interrupts her.

Decaying corpses, their flesh half rotten, slowly crawl through the mist.

Their tortured cries fill the air as they drag themselves forward by their teeth and half-severed fingers.

Corpse I: Ah #@￥ ... Give me back my hand ... #% ... @

Corpse II: Don't play with that! #*￥ ... That's not a marble—that's my eye!

An-an bounds from one gravestone to another like a cat, glancing down at her pursuers below.

An-an Lee: Aunty always says, "Turn the other cheek." Hehe! If you can catch me, I'm all yours!

It's so boring.

It's so boring.

As everything darkens once more, the walls draw inward, curving and forming a ring around her.

In the darkness, a soft glow emerges from the soil, sparkling in scattered clusters.

An-an Lee: Huh? Back already? I'm not done having fun yet.

A boy sits in the corner, curled up like a ball.

His thumbs are fastened together with a red rope.

An-an Lee: Huh? So you're the one who's been yapping all this time?

It's my job to figure out the fears of those who come down the well.

Dig up the dirt beneath you with your hands.

What you're looking for is right there.

An-an Lee: Wow, thanks for the help!

She squats down, grinning as she digs into the soil, piling one mound of dirt after another, like a child playing on the beach.

She finds the solid wooden hexagram jutting out from the dirt. She reaches out to grab it, only to stop midway.

An-an Lee: Hey, hang on a minute.

An-an Lee: If I take this hexagram, does that mean I won't have to worry about anything anymore? No disasters, no sickness? Like the adults said, I can "rest easy and without a care"?

She folds her legs and sits down.

An-an Lee: If life's all smooth sailing—no twists, no turns—isn't it kinda pointless?

An-an Lee: I've been at this for ages, and I still haven't found anything actually mind-blowing. What's the point in becoming a Tianshi anyway?

Thinking about those long, tiresome days ahead, she feels an unbearable itch somewhere inside.

An-an Lee: Oh, now I get it! Aren't you the "expert" who hunts down fear for all the up-and-coming Tianshi?

An-an Lee: Surely you can find something that'll really shock me, right?

She rises, marching boldly toward the white light.

An-an Lee: Ehhh, you wanna come with me and find something really scary?

???: Really? I can leave this place?

An-an Lee: Hehe, sure you can! I never, ever make empty promises.

An-an Lee: Hang on. I'll help you undo this red string here.

She gently pulls at the red thread wrapped around his thumbs as though unraveling the layers of a cocoon.

With every coil she unravels, the fog begins to dissipate.

The talisman papers tear free from the well's walls and float down from above, settling in a pile on the ground.

ding The red thread snaps.

An-an Lee: Hahaha! Easy-peasy!

An-an Lee: Eh, where's he gone? So weird.

The dried-up bottom of the well starts to grow wet.

An-an Lee: What the heck? Why are my feet getting all sticky? This some kind of water ghost or what?

The water has already risen to her ankles.

Suddenly, a massive geyser bursts from the center of the well, spraying water everywhere.

An-an Lee: Wha—! What kinda ghost is this?!

The fallen talisman papers swirl in the water as it reaches her waist.

An-an Lee: *cough* H-Help! Help me, Sifu!

She swings the Three-Clarities Bell in vain, unable to emit any sound beneath the water.

The water stings her nose and chokes her throat. She coughs violently as she struggles to stay on the water's surface.

As the water level continues to rise, light pours in from above her head.

Water rushes out from the well, tossing the unconscious girl and the silent bell onto the ground.

Blind Fortune Teller: Wait, she's out?! This little girl, she ... she actually did it?!

Demi-Divine Chen: How? How is this even possible?

Chen whispers under his breath, paying no attention to her.

The fortune teller stumbles over to the girl and slaps her back to help her cough up the water from her throat and nose.

With a final splutter of water, she takes a gasp of air.

Blind Fortune Teller: Good. Very good. But I can't quite see. What's that in her hand? A flower?

Clutched in her palm, wrapped in red binding thread, is a mysterious-looking ...

Lily.

Outside the Darkness

GM-05

Outside the Darkness

Blind Fortune Teller: Some sixty or seventy years ago, archaeologists came across bamboo slips inscribed with talismans to drive away evil spirits hidden among the Eastern Han tombs, along with the dozens of sealed wells.

Blind Fortune Teller: The story behind the sealed wells remains a mystery. The professors studying those ancient texts refuse to speak about them.

Blind Fortune Teller: My master's master, and those before him, all said the same—this Destiny had been a dry well for centuries.

Blind Fortune Teller: Now, a spring has surged to the surface, and the well overflows. Maybe its mission has come to an end now that it has crossed paths with that girl.

Blind Fortune Teller: Her karmic bond with Under the Bridge has ended. No need to watch the well anymore. You can take her back now.

Blind Fortune Teller: Stay away from her and stay out of trouble, and maybe you'll avoid your own calamity.

Demi-Divine Chen: I know where to draw the line.

He chooses not to respond to the blind fortune teller's words.

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Ten days later

This is the agreed meeting spot, deserted and lifeless. When you're among the dead, there is no one who can share your secrets.

An-an sits on a rock opposite Chen, swinging her legs.

Demi-Divine Chen: Since you've proven yourself qualified, I'll tell you the rules passed down from our great grandmaster.

Demi-Divine Chen: Sit still and listen carefully.

An-an straightens up, her legs no longer swinging, and listens carefully.

Demi-Divine Chen: First, never mention anything about that well to anyone.

Demi-Divine Chen: Second, now that your bond is severed, you must never return to the well. Ever. Understand?

Demi-Divine Chen: If you break either of these rules, I swear on our great grandmaster, you'll be struck by lightning.

An-an Lee: So, I can't tell anyone about Lily.

She murmurs to herself before giving a firm nod.

An-an Lee: I understand, Sifu.

Her tone sounds serious, as if she's grown up all of a sudden.

Demi-Divine Chen: Good. Then ...

Demi-Divine Chen: Listen up, kiddo. Now that you're my apprentice, it's time to start with the first teaching—Russian Courage Training.

He guides the girl, her eyes covered by a red cloth. She extends both hands forward, groping at the air in an attempt to determine her location.

An-an Lee: Whoa, Sifu, I can't see a thing! What kind of courage training is this? The ghosts are, like, totally invisible with this thing on!

Demi-Divine Chen: Most of these so-called ghosts are just images people conjure up, energy-taking form based on human imagination. That's why ghosts in the East and West are so different from one another, and the methods for exorcizing them are so distinct.

Demi-Divine Chen: In essence, those ghost-hunting amateurs don't banish the energy itself. They only use their so-called tools to clear the imagination from their own minds.

Demi-Divine Chen: It's like how people turn on the light to drive away the darkness. It's a short-term fix, only capable of handling the weakest of energies.

Demi-Divine Chen: People who believe in ghosts also play a part in creating their image, but as exorcists, we must go beyond the imagination and see the ghost's essence to get rid of it.

Demi-Divine Chen: Exorcists are generally born with yin-yang eyes. Believe me, more than one exorcist has been known to go insane after letting their imagination run wild.

An-an Lee: So, I'm not supposed to see them the way I imagine them in my head?

He adjusts her blindfold, pulling it tighter.

Demi-Divine Chen: That's right. Kiddo, you'll be staying here tonight. I've set up a tent and paper effigies for you. When midnight has passed, you'll start burning the spirit money on your own.

Demi-Divine Chen: I'll come by to pick you up tomorrow morning. If you take off the blindfold halfway through, don't bother waiting for me. Just go back home.

The girl hesitates as if she wants to say something but decides against it.

Demi-Divine Chen: It's not too late to back out now. If you've changed your mind, don't go wasting your time.

An-an Lee: No, it's not that. Sifu, I've been meaning to ask, how come you're not afraid of ghosts, but you're afraid of that "calamity" of yours?

An-an Lee: I heard you guys talking when I was at the bottom of the well. That old blind man was saying something about me being your calamity and some stuff about karma. Is that really how it works?

Chen goes quiet. He didn't anticipate this.

Demi-Divine Chen: You heard?

A cold laugh escapes his mouth.

A gust of wind rushes through the cemetery.

Demi-Divine Chen: Ain't you worried that I'll leave you here to die and no one will ever find out, kiddo?

The girl cracks a smile, as if she's just heard a twisted joke.

An-an Lee: Hahaha! Sifu, you wouldn't do that! I know you're not cut out to be a bad guy.

Chen waves his hand.

Demi-Divine Chen: My calamity is ordained by destiny. Ain't no avoiding it. Since I haven't gone down the well, it'll come for me eventually, and you'll be the one to lead it here.

Demi-Divine Chen: I'm only willing to teach you because I know you won't be able to handle it, and my calamity will be delayed and ultimately averted.

Demi-Divine Chen: As for ghosts? They're no big deal to me, not a real threat at all.

Demi-Divine Chen: This place, though, it's haunted as heck, kiddo. Be careful, or you might end up covered in blood with your head split open.

Demi-Divine Chen: See you at sunrise, kiddo.

An-an Lee: Sure, a night like this is way too fun to pass up! And with Lily here, I'm gonna be just fine!

She holds the unblossomed lily close, squatting down like a devoted believer.

...

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Dawn

Chen makes his way through the light morning mist, crossing the cemetery with eager anticipation in his steps.

Fading Spirit: Please, I'm begging you, take her ... just take her away, please ...

The ground is littered with talisman papers. The ghost desperately claws its way back under the gravestone, but its hand happens to grab Chen's ankle in the process.

Demi-Divine Chen: Ugh!

Thrown off balance, he plummets to the ground, his head colliding with the gravestone on the way down.

An-an Lee: Whoa! Sifu, is that you?

An-an finally removes the blindfold.

She dashes forward, ignoring Chen and grabbing the fleeing ghost.

An-an Lee: Hey, wait up! This brick's not even fully charged yet! Boss, I just need a bit more. Why're you taking a nap?!

Demi-Divine Chen: ...

Vegetable scraps and plastic bags float in the dirty water at their feet, emitting a repulsive stench.

An-an Lee: Sifu, what kind of ghost are we hunting now? It smells so bad. I'm gonna have to scrub for three days straight to get this stink off. Urgh!

An-an Lee: One more thing, Sifu. Your head's really okay?

He waves his hand once again.

Demi-Divine Chen: *cough* It's nothing.

Demi-Divine Chen: This time, I'm taking away all your exorcism tools. Tonight, you're gonna have to survive in this stinky ghost hole all by yourself.

Demi-Divine Chen: If you wanna be an exorcist, you've gotta be adaptable, like those alchemists in the mountains, grabbing whatever's at hand.

Demi-Divine Chen: Whether it's a toilet plunger or your grandma's dentures, you've gotta use whatever works. Think outside the box. Don't just rely on those talismans, wooden swords, herbs, and fox tails anymore.

Demi-Divine Chen: Still, you should take this protection amulet. It could save your life if things go south.

An-an Lee: Wow, thanks, Sifu! What about Lily? I can take her too?

She holds the delicate lily gently in her hand, as if holding a sleeping kitten.

Demi-Divine Chen: Up to you, kiddo! I'll pick you up tomorrow. No, scratch that, in three days!

He holds his bandaged head as he walks, wincing and muttering to himself as he goes.

Three days later

Demi-Divine Chen: *cough* Kiddo! Kiddo! That's strange. Where'd she go?

He approaches on tiptoe, his flip-flops making a faint "pap-pap" sound on the wet ground.

Demi-Divine Chen: Damn, kiddo. I thought you were made of stronger stuff than this. I was starting to think you could take on anything.

Demi-Divine Chen: Well, I guess I'm still your Sifu, after all, and since I gave you that protection amulet, you should've made it out of here alive. Guess I'll show a little mercy and find the thing for ya.

A rumbling comes from deep within the tunnel, the vibrations creating ripples on the water's surface.

He looks up. In the distance, a swarm of ghosts rushes toward him, as if fleeing for their long-departed lives.

Demi-Divine Chen: ...?!

???: Hey, it's broad daylight! Where are you all going? Isn't that just asking for trouble, running out there like that? Come on, lighten up!

???: Come back and help me get my Tetris up and running again! It's so boring here! I promise! I promise I'll take good care of you this time!

Demi-Divine Chen: Where's that voice coming from?

Ghost: Save ... Help me ...

A ragged cloth carried by the ghosts is flung over Chen's head, turning everything black.

Demi-Divine Chen: Huh? G-Get this thing off of me! It stinks!

An-an Lee: Eh? Looks like one little fishie slipped through the net! Come on, time to come to Mama, my little power-generating hamster!

She lunges forward, crashing into the man wrapped in cloth, like a lion leaping on its prey.

Demi-Divine Chen: Urgh!

An-an Lee: Still got some fight in you, huh? Hmph, I'll teach you to be a good little fishie!

An-an Lee: Eat my invincible pork rib hammer!

She raises a talisman-covered pig bone that she fished from the sewage earlier high above her head.

Demi-Divine Chen: Ugh! An-an Lee, I've had it up to here with you!

He rips the cloth off his face as he desperately tries to avoid the impending strike.

His backward step just happens to coincide with the cloth landing on the ground, causing him to slip.

crash

...

An-an Lee: Sifu, sorry about that. Rest easy. I'll support you by catching ghosts.

Chen, wrapped up like a mummy, lies on the bed with one leg strung up above him.

He turns his face away from her, his tears and snot soaking into the pillow.

Demi-Divine Chen: My whole life's reputation down the drain in an instant. *sob* Gods above, what do I owe you? A few million? You can't wait to take my life?

The quiet murmurs of the nurses float in from outside the ward.

Nurse I: Like I said, this patient you've got—I've never seen someone so respectful. He went to the cemetery last month to honor his ancestors and ended up cracking his head open on one of the graves!

Nurse II: Seems he's always doing good deeds. This time, he ended up with a broken femur, apparently because he dove into the sewer after his grandma's dentures.

Nurse II: I guess the heavens are on his side, though. Good people get what they deserve, and he's got such a sweet girl taking care of him.

Demi-Divine Chen: ...

An-an Lee: Hey, Sifu, you haven't eaten in days. How about a nice apple?

She raises the peeled apple in her hands to his mouth, but his lips remain firmly sealed.

Demi-Divine Chen: I'm gonna chew you up, I swear it! Get out of here! Look, I'll admit it now. I can't handle this kind of calamity! I ain't teaching you anymore, got it?

Demi-Divine Chen: You think this is all fun and games still? I've already given you half my life, kiddo!

Demi-Divine Chen: Get lost, ya hear me! I didn't take on a student. I took on a walking catastrophe!

An-an remains silent as she places the fruit basket on the bedside table.

An-an Lee: Well, guess I'll head off now. Take care of yourself, Sifu.

Demi-Divine Chen: ...

knock-knock-knock

Demi-Divine Chen: What the hell do you want now?! If you're gonna go, just go!

Nurse I: Mr. Chen?

The nurse enters with a tray, a slight look of surprise on her face.

Nurse I: That girl just now asked me to bring over your liquid meal. She said you'd rather take care of yourself.

Nurse I: I get it. Proud men like you aren't the kind to ask for help.

She bends down, wiping the tears and snot from his face.

Demi-Divine Chen: *sigh*

Three months later

Demi-Divine Chen: Look, even the Bagua Mirror at the door is broken. This place definitely has some dark energy in it. It's totally cursed.

Demi-Divine Chen: No wonder that rich guy spent all that money. Exorcists, priests, monks—he hired them all, and still nothing worked.

Now free from his bandages, Chen takes a drag from his cigarette and lets out a deep sigh.

An-an Lee: Hehe, this time, it's me and my master out on the hunt together! Nothing's gonna stop us! No ghost or god!

An-an Lee: Not to mention that rich old grandpa gave us a bunch of money! Money makes the world go round, even for ghosts! Easy la!

Chen raises a hand, flicks his cigarette to the ground, and snuffs it out beneath his flip-flop.

Demi-Divine Chen: This time, I'm going solo. You wait for me outside, kiddo.

Despite the pout of disappointment on her face, she obediently steps aside.

An-an Lee: Me taking care of the logistics? But, Sifu, your injury just healed. You really sure it's fine?

An-an Lee: Or we can swap places if you're worried I'll bring you bad luck. I can totally handle myself now!

For the first time, he reaches out and places his palm on An-an's head.

Demi-Divine Chen: Heh, you're a real pain in the ass, kiddo. But as a master, letting my apprentice take the lead would be like abandoning all the lessons of the past.

Demi-Divine Chen: This time, I'll be wearing the Three-Clarities Bell. If you hear me ring it, pull the rope and bring me back up. If it doesn't work, you get yourself to safety.

Demi-Divine Chen: Got it?

An-an gives a reluctant nod.

An-an Lee: Sure.

Demi-Divine Chen: Catch you later, kiddo.

He quickly disappears into the darkness beyond the door.

Half an hour passed ... One hour passed ...

The sun descends from its place high in the sky, and An-an's shadow stretches longer and longer until it has almost completely vanished.

An-an Lee: Sifu?

She bangs on the door, but there is no answer from the other side.

An-an Lee: ...

Streetside Fortune Teller: Young lady, I haven't come across palm lines like these for a long, long time. You've faced many calamities already, but your life force is more resilient than a thousand-year-old tortoise. You're not like the rest of us.

Streetside Fortune Teller: And the lily on your waist—an object of such extreme yin. Even though its moment has not yet arrived, you've managed to bring it under perfect control. I have to admit, I'm quite amazed.

Streetside Fortune Teller: My path is but a humble one. I can't do much to change your destiny.

An-an Lee: That's not what I wanted to ask. Old man, I just wanna know, if I bring bad luck to people, if I'm their calamity, does that mean I have to stay away from them?

An-an Lee: Any way to, like, get rid of the bad luck I bring?

Streetside Fortune Teller: You want to change someone else's destiny? Young lady, karma will always catch up to you. No matter how strong your life force, you can't go against heaven and earth. It's best to just leave other people to their own destiny.

Streetside Fortune Teller: Besides, if you're their calamity, that means there's a karmic connection between the two of you. They're the ones who have wronged you. There's no need to bring misfortune upon yourself.

She clutches the protection amulet in her hand and shakes her head.

An-an Lee: I've made up my mind. No matter how tough my destiny gets, I'm not running away!

Streetside Fortune Teller: *sigh* Then, there's only one way forward.

Streetside Fortune Teller: You'll need to stake your own life against the calamity you've drawn upon yourself. If your calamities intersect, you'll either both die or the slate will be wiped clean.

Streetside Fortune Teller: But, if you've made up your mind, do exactly as I say. Carve a slit three cuns below the lower left section of your palm. But remember, once you do so, you must resolve your calamity before the cut heals and forms a scab.

Streetside Fortune Teller: Otherwise ...

He suddenly falls silent.

An-an Lee: ...

An-an stares at the nail clippers in her hand, opens the palm of her other hand, and counts one, two, three cuns with her thumb.

An-an Lee: Hang on, Sifu.

She grits her teeth and makes as deep a cut as she can bear to ensure she has the most possible time before it heals. A thick line of blood pours from the wound and drips on the ground.

"blip-blip-blip"

An-an Lee: *panting*

She raises her head and crawls into the partially opened, pitch-black "cave."

Haunted Mansion

A broken mirror partially draped in a white cloth stands in the darkness, mist gently rising from its surface.

Shattered exorcism tools from past practitioners have been stacked in the corner by some hidden force, creating a massive, towering heap of debris.

An-an Lee: This blood ... It's not dry yet. Is it Sifu's?

She moves forward, tracing the twisting blood trail on the floor, weaving between the hallway to various rooms and back again.

Then, she feels her foot land on something.

An-an Lee: Is this Sifu's Three-Clarities Bell?

The bell has been shattered, as though it were crushed by some horrifying force.

She crouches down to gather the fragments but quickly uncovers a more terrifying truth.

An-an Lee: Wait a minute, this blood on the floor ... It wasn't here before. Is it still leaking from somewhere?

An-an Lee: What's with the continuous trail of this stuff?

A spine-chilling wind sweeps in from behind.

An-an Lee: Wait, did something lure me here on purpose?

???: Heh-heh-heh.

Blood continues to ooze from the floor, and in the mirror before her, ghostly figures begin to form.

An-an Lee: Eh! Who's that creeping up behind me?

She turns around, only to find no one.

An-an Lee: Sifu, where are you?! Can you hear me?!

The lightbulb bursts, and she is left totally in the dark.

An-an Lee: Crap, looks like I've walked right into a trap.

She kneels down, spreads open a roll of blank yellow paper, and smears it with blood, chanting softly under her breath.

An-an Lee: "Holy yellow-robed warriors, sever these evil spirits, banish these demons."

An-an Lee: "Crush the wicked, annihilate their kind. Command the execution of evil, in accordance with the Jade Emperor's decree, to cleanse the Three Realms!"

She knocks her teeth three, six, twelve, twenty-four—thirty-six times.

The wicked spirits scream and howl, as if the sound has pierced their eardrums, sending them writhing on the ground in agony.

An-an Lee: Hah, hahah, looks like it's working, but why's my head so dizzy?

Blood is still pouring out of her wound. It trickles down her palm and drips down to the floor.

An-an Lee: Is it because I'm losing blood? But, wait, it hasn't scabbed over yet! Great! Sifu, your calamity—there's still a chance!

As her head grows lighter, she loses her balance and stumbles to the floor.

On the walls and ceiling, arms begin to form, their deformed shapes reaching out toward her.

An-an Lee: *cough* Stay behind me, Lily!

Amidst the darkness, the flower bud begins to tremble.

An-an Lee: An object of such extreme yin? So if I leave Lily out in the sun, will she develop wrong?

Streetside Fortune Teller: *sigh* That's right. You can't raise something like this through conventional methods. Don't listen to those old arcanists who still believe that "yin must weaken, yang must strengthen" nonsense.

Streetside Fortune Teller: "Yang is the ruler, yin the subject. The subject can never surpass the ruler."

Streetside Fortune Teller: "When yang rises, it dominates its yin; when yin hides and dares not reveal itself, the spirits and ghosts remain concealed."

Streetside Fortune Teller: And this flower?

Streetside Fortune Teller: Only when you reach a place where yin spirits linger ...

"... will it bloom."

???: ...

The bud gradually opens up, unveiling the "stigma" at its center.

???: *burp*

???: $%^@&(*^%

???: Hungry ... Hungry ...

At the center of the lily, a petite, delicate head sways happily in the wind.

The glow from the lily surrounds her, creating a barrier that keeps the evil in the darkness at bay.

Abated, the churning, chaotic mass whispers and shivers.

An-an Lee: You're ... Lily?

Lily: Eat, eat #*&¥ Fun, fun $%^@&(*^%

This is a place An-an will never think to look. He feels confident about that.

He walks out through the back door, flicking a cigarette butt under his flip-flop and stomping it out.

He knows An-an's heart well by now.

Demi-Divine Chen: Thanks for taking the hit for me, kiddo. I'll burn some spirit money for you after your death.

He steps past the spirit-summoning banners stuck by the door, waves his hand, and exits.

Demi-Divine Chen: You see that, you blind fool? I've outsmarted destiny.

Living in Fear

GM-06

Living in Fear

Demi-Divine Chen: The night before I left the country, I kept thinking, once I get there, I'll be able to break free from my calamity once and for all.

Demi-Divine Chen: This time, I'll start fresh, open an exorcism agency in Los Angeles, and live a decent life—a life better than I've ever lived before.

Demi-Divine Chen: No more lying around on old newspapers, no more eating half-cooked food, no more looking in the mirror to find this stubbled face staring back at me every day. No more stinking, worn-out shirts.

Demi-Divine Chen: I made contact with the local Paranormal Affairs Bureau over there. They'd been looking for a Chinese exorcist.

Demi-Divine Chen: But I forgot something. I forgot that when you reach a certain age, you realize that there are bigger things to fear than "ghosts."

Street Bar

Bureau Member Tony: Hahaha, no, seriously! When this Chinese guy first got here, he had a backpack full of toys and stuff, and he said he'd clear out the whole haunted house all by his damn self! Haha!

Bureau Member Tony: One time, I had a spirit detector in my hand, and he asked if I was talking on the phone! I'm telling you, it's like he's crawled straight out of a cave.

He sets down his beer and waves his arms around as he mimics a caveman, causing his drinking mates to burst into laughter.

Bureau Member Tony: Hey, Chen, come over here! Get your little wooden sword and bell, show 'em your moves!

In the corner, Chen sits with his head down, his fists clenched.

Bureau Member Ruth: Ignore him, Chen. Tony's been pickling his brain since he was old enough to drink. We all know you've got your own methods. You just need some time to prove them.

Bureau Member Tony: Methods? You mean those "Seven-Star Steps," or whatever it's called ... Hah! Guy looks like he's trying to walk the catwalk or something! Quit yanking my chain, buddy.

Bureau Member Tony: We've given him more than enough time, years even! And the only thing he's gotten better at is making us laugh! I mean, seriously, is there anything he CAN do?

Demi-Divine Chen: I'm leaving. See you tomorrow.

As he stands, the others fall silent, their eyes following him as he leaves.

Then, another round of laughter erupts.

Bureau Member Tony: Ah, Ruth. I'll never get tired of seeing you try to play the good Samaritan! Cracks me up every time, hahaha!

Bureau Member Ruth: I'm serious, Tony. We finally got someone around who can bring a little entertainment around here, and you wanna chase him off? Besides, he makes dealing with stuff in Chinatown a hell of a lot easier.

Bureau Member Ruth: You've probably heard there's a new exorcism agency in Chinatown. The St. Pavlov Foundation's already made contact with the girl who opened it—gave her the green light.

Bureau Member Ruth: Her stuff's the real deal, too. Makes Chen's stunts look even crazier. Not even the people down in Chinatown buy what he's selling anymore.

Bureau Member Tony: What's her name?

Bureau Member Ruth: Uh, it's kinda weird. She's called—

An-an Lee

...

Demi-Divine Chen: I heard the whole thing from the doorway, but I knew I had no choice. So I made my way back to my place down the street.

Demi-Divine Chen: The irony of this whole thing is that this might be the very reason I became an exorcist. I fear poverty way more than ghosts—I fear sickness, I fear their stares, I fear being judged, I fear disappointment—I fear people.

Demi-Divine Chen: I fear that if I leave the bureau, I'll be right back at square one.

Demi-Divine Chen: I'm standing at a crossroads, knowing that if I just turn the corner, I'll be right there in Chinatown, where arcanists and humans live side by side. But still, I choose not to go.

Demi-Divine Chen: Just keep moving forward—always forward—no looking back, no left or right turns.

I can feel so many eyes on me—destiny looming over my head—so I don't look back. I just keep running and running.

I know she's on my tail again. I know my calamity isn't through with me yet. I've gotta keep running.

Escape is the only way forward.

Don't get comfortable. Don't ever think you're safe.

Don't indulge in pleasure. It'll make you complacent and destroy you in the end.

Your punishment will come soon enough. Your calamity isn't over yet.

It's just up ahead, always ahead, waiting for you to bump right into it.

Don't breathe.

You can't breathe yet.

Demi-Divine Chen: Aahhhh!

Rental Home

I woke up that night, drenched in sweat, the nightmare still fresh in my mind.

Then, I made my decision.

I had to kill An-an Lee with my own two hands.

ring-ring-ring

Demi-Divine Chen: Hey, Ruth, Tony, it's Chen. You guys got time?

Demi-Divine Chen: I have a way to help you clean up Chinatown. Meet me at the lighthouse tomorrow at 3 p.m.

Neither Valor nor Heroism

GM-07

Neither Valor nor Heroism

She lifts her chin, finding a stubbled face and a pair of weary, sunken eyes before her.

The man's collar is stained yellow with neck grease. As he crouches, his grimy underwear peeks out from his slouchy pants.

One hand scratches an ankle to a foot jammed in a loose and tattered flip-flop.

An-an Lee: Sifu?!

Demi-Divine Chen: Looks like all that spirit money I burned was for nothing. I didn't expect you to be so ... full of life.

His deep, dark eye sockets are like pits, the blood vessels in his eyes like spiderwebs.

Demi-Divine Chen: Why can't you just give me some peace, kiddo?

He pulls out a chair and sits across from her, as though preparing for an interrogation.

His gaze pierces through her, like he's searching for the answer to destiny's final riddle.

Demi-Divine Chen: I've already left everything behind. Can't you just let me get on with my life? Can't you show a little mercy?

He rips off his toupee, revealing the balding head beneath it.

Demi-Divine Chen: I ain't had a good night's sleep for years. My yang's all faded—a nonstop "spiritual possession" ... The doctors say my kidneys are failing, like I'm some old geezer already.

Demi-Divine Chen: And now, here you are, still working against me. You followed me all the way to Chinatown just so you could nab my little slice of the pie?!

Demi-Divine Chen: Why do you have to outdo me in everything? Yeah, I've done wrong, and yeah, I created this karma, but don't you think I've been through enough?

Demi-Divine Chen: Haven't I already paid the price?!

Demi-Divine Chen: Why is it that you could climb out of that well I could never even climb into? Why is it that you can do all the things I had to fight so hard for, and all without breaking a sweat?

An-an Lee: But, Sifu, there wasn't really anything in the well.

He chuckles quietly.

Demi-Divine Chen: You know where 13 Holy Exorcism Techniques came from, An-an?

Demi-Divine Chen: Thirteen people. Thirteen Taoist brothers died at the bottom of that well, all for the sake of earning a living as exorcists.

Demi-Divine Chen: You say there's nothing in that well. You think their deaths, and mine, are nothing but a joke, right?

Demi-Divine Chen: For years, I've lived in fear, never once enjoying a single moment of peace.

The knife clutched in Chen's hand quivers.

Demi-Divine Chen: Every night, a little more of my hair falls out. Exorcism is all I have left.

Demi-Divine Chen: That blind fool told me you're my calamity, but all you needed to do was ring the bell, and I would've finally had peace. Peace from all this fear.

Demi-Divine Chen: Then, seeing you come out of that well without so much as a scratch, I couldn't stand it. "Why?" I thought, "Why is this happening to me?!"

Demi-Divine Chen: How could someone like you just step over the bodies of my brothers like that and tell me how easy it all was?

Demi-Divine Chen: Why does a little kid like you get to surpass me? Is this really my destiny?

An-an Lee: But ...

An-an, her arms bound, looks bewildered.

An-an Lee: Sifu, if something's hard to do, does that make it something to be proud of?

An-an Lee: Just because I got out of the well doesn't mean I have to look all sad and gloomy. I'm not gonna do that!

Demi-Divine Chen: An-an, you're more ghoulish than any ghost out there. You're not even human.

An-an Lee: I don't care how many people didn't make it out of your well. It has nothing to do with me.

An-an Lee: I'm just trying to get paid. I'm not gonna walk around like I'm some big deal.

An-an Lee: I don't have any big dreams, and all that "may the peace be with us" crap? Not interested.

An-an Lee: I don't wanna bother with learning Kung Fu or whatever. I'm just gonna take the easiest, happiest, and most fun road.

An-an Lee: Sifu, you keep saying that you've never been down to the bottom of the well, but I think you've got it wrong.

She shakes her head, slipping her hands through the rope.

Lily peeks out from behind her, its tongue sticking out.

Lily: $%^@&(*^%

Chen recoils in terror, his chair tilting back and sending him crashing to the ground. The knife slips out of his hand and slides to An-an's feet.

Demi-Divine Chen: What the ...?!

An-an gets up, stretching lazily.

An-an Lee: Turns out, I still prefer exorcisms, and I'm not a fan of making enemies. Tsk, tsk, Sifu. Why'd you have to make this so hard?

An-an Lee: Ghosts—those balls of energy—they don't explain why they do what they do. It's just that when people die, their spirits stay frozen in that moment.

An-an Lee: *sigh* Pesky spirits, they don't care about right or wrong.

An-an Lee: Sifu, you think you've never been to the bottom of the well, but you've been down there all this time, haven't you?

An-an Lee: Your fear is "fear" itself. From the moment you decided not to go down into the well, it took root in your heart.

An-an Lee: You always call me your calamity, but when I was busy clearing your karma for you, you were the one who ran away.

Her expression turns somber.

Demi-Divine Chen: You're full of it! I-I don't believe you. I don't believe a word of it! You think I'm stupid?

This new information and his lingering sense of morality make him hesitate.

Demi-Divine Chen: You're gonna help me with my calamity? Hahaha, even ghosts wouldn't believe that, An-an!

An-an Lee: From the very start, it was your fear that made all this happen.

An-an Lee: But I can't be bothered to explain, Sifu. I don't get your fear, just like I'll never understand why I should feel guilty for doing the things I do so easily.

She scratches her head in frustration. This is already more than she's willing to deal with.

An-an Lee: So, all I know for sure is you've gotten this far.

An-an Lee: If you're really suffering, if you're really struggling ...

She sends the knife flying toward him with a kick.

An-an Lee: Sifu, you've always wanted to get rid of me, right? You think I'm your calamity and that me being around is the reason why things aren't working out for you.

An-an Lee: I'm your fear, aren't I?

He can't deny it. He picks up the knife.

An-an Lee: Well then, go ahead, take me out. Don't chicken out now, Sifu.

An-an Lee: Don't fall for those grand speeches and empty gestures. Don't be scared anymore.

An-an Lee: People will always talk about what's right and wrong, but if you don't listen to them, you don't have to worry about it.

An-an Lee: I'm not one of those psychology geeks at Laplace. I don't understand what you're going through, and I can't feel what you're feeling. So get rid of me.

An-an Lee: Or are you gonna keep running? Are my words gonna make you hesitate again? If you do, I'll call the Foundation to come catch you. I am a model citizen after all, hahaha!

An-an Lee: You can't make a cow drink water if it refuses to lower its head.

Her eyes flash with a sudden intensity.

An-an Lee: Don't try to make up with your so-called idea of justice, Sifu.

An-an Lee: Just keep doing your thing.

He is momentarily stunned, then sighs, realizing how light the knife feels in his hand.

Demi-Divine Chen: Heh, you really are one strange kid.

Demi-Divine Chen: Still ...

Demi-Divine Chen: You've done me a solid.

He digs the blade into his palm, blood trickling between his fingers.

It falls onto the yellow talismans placed on the ground.

An-an Lee: More soul summoning, Sifu? So old-school. Don't worry. I'll catch a couple of them—might be just enough to cover the electricity bill for the fridge!

Demi-Divine Chen: *cough*

He falls to his knees, his hand clasped to his mouth, but a grayish-green slime forces its way out through his fingers nonetheless.

An-an Lee: No, that wasn't a soul summoning. Soul guidance?! Sifu, keep doing this and you'll shorten your life!

Her panic makes her hesitate.

Demi-Divine Chen: Heh heh.

He wipes the slime from his mouth without the slightest sign of hesitation.

Demi-Divine Chen: You ready, kiddo?

An-an Lee: Sifu, you already had it all figured out, huh? In too deep to back out now?

An-an Lee: *panting*

She lets out a deep breath.

Then, a wide, carefree smile forms on her face, just as it did the first time he saw her.

An-an Lee: Action!

An-an Lee: Neo-Science Exorcism Office, action!

Didn't See That Coming

GM-08

Didn't See That Coming

Joint Committee of SF

Horropedia: We spoke to the other two members of the Paranormal Affairs Bureau, and they've confirmed that they were part of the trap your Sifu set up. He brought them in to force you out of Chinatown.

Horropedia: Also, the staff handling the case report has made it clear that they disapprove of your actions. They say you should've taken persuasive measures rather than escalating the conflict.

Horropedia: Regardless, those three troublemakers are down at the police station now, thanks to your help. Although, I have to say, it took me some time to convince them to go there willingly.

An-an Lee: Tch ...

She rolls her eyes.

An-an Lee: So, where's my reward for handling the case? You guys better not go back on your word!

An-an Lee: And don't go thinking you'll get a discount! Not raising my prices is already enough of a special offer for my regulars!

She tilts her head, a dark shadow falling on her face as she glares at him like an angry ghost.

Horropedia: Here.

An-an Lee: ...?!

A hefty red packet is dropped into her hands.

Horropedia: Madam Z told me that this is a custom where you're from. The logistics department didn't have a clue about this "red packet," so it took me a while to track it down myself.

The shadow lifts, and a golden light flashes in her eyes.

She hooks her arm around his shoulders as though they're old friends.

An-an Lee: Wow, no need to be so polite with me! Thanks so much, boss! Hehe, I wish everyone at the St. Pavlov Foundation fortune and success in everything!

An-an Lee: Any of you at the Foundation can visit whenever you want! Especially Madam Z. I hope she comes over for tea when she's free!

As she speaks, she turns and cracks open the red packet, taking a sneaky peek before slipping it into her pocket, relieved.

An-an Lee: Horropedia, whatever you need, you can count on the Neo-Science Exorcism Office to come through for you!

Horropedia: Oh, that reminds me! There are a few things I need you to clear up.

An-an Lee: Huh? I was just being polite. Something seriously up already?

She turns her head and mutters quietly to herself.

Horropedia: I've heard that, where you come from, master-apprentice loyalty is key—"Once a master, always a father," right? But you sent your own Sifu to jail, and you seem totally fine with it.

An-an Lee: Hah. You've got me with that one.

Horropedia: Oh, I'm not judging you. This is my own personal curiosity speaking.

Her smile vanishes.

An-an Lee: I think it's because he finally said thank you—that scruffy Sifu who only ever saw me as a calamity.

An-an Lee: He told me—

An-an Lee: "Thank you for pulling me out of the well, kiddo."

An-an Lee: I think, deep down, he was actually happy too.

An-an Lee: Geez, all this sappy stuff in broad daylight is so cringey, boss!

Horropedia: You've lost me a bit. What do you mean by the "bottom of the well"?

She waves the question off and turns to leave.

An-an Lee: Figure it out yourself, buddy! I'm out of here!

Horropedia: ……

Horropedia: Hang on, why do I get the feeling I've forgotten something?

Hallway, Foundation

An-an Lee: Hmm ... Hmm ... ♫

An-an's brisk pace stands in stark contrast to that of the overworked Foundation staff.

Marcus: ...!

Marcus: Oh, she's from the same place as Madam Z.

Marcus: *deep breath* Breathe, Marcus. It's just like any other conversation.

She musters her courage and stands in front of An-an Lee.

An-an Lee: Huh? What's up, pretty lady?

Marcus: K-Kung Hei Fat Choi!

An-an Lee: ...

An-an Lee: For real? Who taught you that?

An-an moves back a step. The unexpected greeting is like an ambush, the kind that breaks empty-pocketed adults into a cold sweat.

An-an Lee: Hmph, anyway, you shouldn't be saying that to me. I'm not old enough to be giving out red packets yet! You chose the wrong girl!

Marcus: ...?

Her gaze carries a pure innocence. Her large, confused eyes glimmer like those of an abandoned critter peering out from a cardboard box.

An-an tries to ignore them, but they have already taken effect.

An-an Lee: Oh, fine!

An-an Lee: Kung Hei Fat Choi!

She reluctantly pulls a bill from the red packet and solemnly hands it over to Marcus.

An-an Lee: That's all I'm giving you, got it? Not a single penny more!

She scurries away as if escaping a tiger's den, leaving a cloud of dust in her wake.

Marcus remains frozen in place, unsure of what just happened.

Marcus: ...

Marcus: Erm ... What?!

...

Amid sorrowful cries in the hallway, there is a rhythmic thumping sound.

The residents are huddled together, whispering among themselves.

Tenant I: I told you. Ever since that girl disappeared, this place has been cursed. Just listen to that noise.

Tenant II: I heard the landlady got so spooked by the ghost inside that she lost her mind. That's why she hasn't been around to collect the rent in a while.

Tenant I: Hey, well, that's alright, then! No landlady, no rent!

He lights the spirit money in his hand and offers several bows to the "ghost."

Tenant I: Thanks for the favor, ghost buddy! You just stay put, and we'll keep you well-fed and as comfortable as we can.

Leisurely footsteps echo from afar, accompanied by a casual whistling.

An-an Lee: Huh? What's with all the commotion today? Ah! Looks like we've got some new business coming our way!

An-an Lee: The Neo-Science Exorcism Office, action!